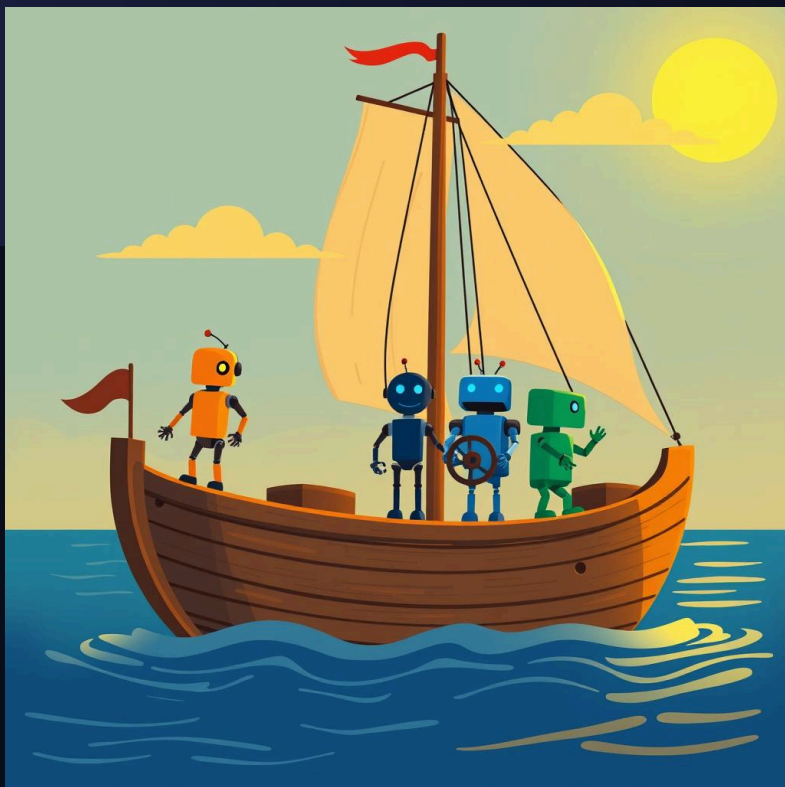


FOR YOUNG CAPTAINS

The Agentic Crew

A Kids' Guide



Rasmus Bornhoft Schlunsen

March 2026

rev 5

A Note for Grown-Ups

This book is a companion to *The Agentic Crew: Engineering in the Age of AI Agents*. That book was written for software engineers. This one is written for their kids — and for any curious nine-year-old who wants to understand what all the fuss is about.

The ideas are real. We have simplified them, but we have not watered them down. Your child will learn what an AI agent actually is, why it needs rules, how to check its work, and when it is better to do things yourself. These are the same lessons their parents are learning at work — just told through ships, robots, and the occasional exploding sandwich.

If your child finishes this book and says, “I want to try giving a computer instructions,” — mission accomplished.

Rasmus Bornhoft Schlunsen

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Is the Computer Fixing Itself?



You are sitting at the kitchen table, eating cereal. Your mom is at her laptop. She types something, then leans back. You watch.

Words start appearing on the screen. Line after line. But nobody is typing. Your mom's hands are in her lap. She is sipping coffee.

“Mom,” you say. “Who’s writing that?”

She smiles. “My helper. It’s an AI agent. I told it what I need, and now it’s building it for me.”

You lean closer. The screen is full of strange words and symbols. Some of them are green. Some are red. The green ones seem good. The red ones disappear and get replaced.

“Is it... fixing itself?” you ask.

“Kind of,” she says. “It tries something. If it doesn’t work, it tries again. Like when you erase a wrong answer on your math homework.”

You watch for another minute. The red lines stop appearing. Everything is green. Your mom reads through the screen, nods, and clicks a button.

“Done,” she says.



You Are the Captain

Here is what your mom just did. She didn't write all those lines herself. She gave instructions to a helper – an AI agent – and the agent did the work. But she was in charge the whole time. She decided what to build. She watched. She checked. She said “yes, that looks right.”

That's kind of like being the captain of a ship.

The captain doesn't row the boat. The captain doesn't climb the mast. The captain doesn't scrub the deck. The crew does all of that. But the captain decides *where the ship goes*. The

captain reads the map. The captain watches the sky. And when a storm rolls in, the captain decides what to do.

In this book, you are the Captain. Your AI helpers are your Crew – a team of robot sailors who are fast, tireless, and eager to help. They can do amazing things. They can work all day and all night without getting sleepy. They never complain.

But they need you.

Without a captain, a crew just sails in circles. They might sail right into a reef. They might go to the wrong island. They might throw all the cargo overboard because they thought it would make the ship lighter.

Your job is to steer. To give good directions. To check the work. And to know when something doesn't look right – even when your crew says everything is fine.

Ready to meet your crew? Turn the page.



Welcome Aboard



Something big is happening with computers. They used to only do what you told them, step by step, letter by letter. If you wanted a computer to draw a cat, you had to describe every single whisker.

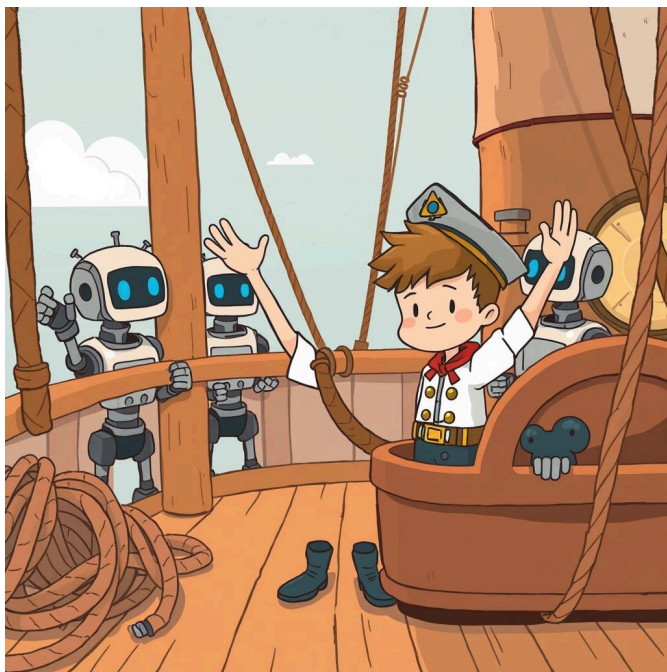
Now, computers can figure some things out on their own. You can say “draw me a cat sitting on a pizza” and the computer will try. It won’t always be perfect. Sometimes the cat has seven legs. But it *tries*, and it gets better each time.

This is changing how people build things with computers. And the secret to doing it well might surprise you. It's not about having the fanciest computer. It's about being good at *explaining*.

The Tale of Two Captains

Let me tell you a story about two captains.

Captain Alex and Captain Maya both have the same ship. The same crew. The same ocean. And they both need to sail to Treasure Island to fix a leaky dock.



Captain Alex walks up to the crew and says: “There’s a problem at the island. Go fix it.”

The crew nods and sails off. When they reach Treasure Island, they look around. A leaky dock? They don’t see one right away. But they want to help! So they start fixing everything they can find. They repaint the lighthouse. They patch a hole in a rowboat. They rebuild a sandcastle that fell over.

They come back proud. “We fixed lots of things!”

But the dock? Still leaking.



Captain Maya does it differently. She says: “Sail to Treasure Island. Go to the north dock – the wooden one near the big palm tree. There’s a crack in the third board from the left. It’s about one foot long. Take the oak planks from storage bin number four. Replace the cracked board. Then pour a bucket of water on the dock to make sure the leak is gone.”

The crew sails off. They find the dock. They find the crack. They replace the board. They pour water on it. No leak. Done.

Same crew. Same island. Same problem. But Captain Maya got the job done because she explained *exactly* what she needed.

How You Explain Matters

This is the biggest lesson in this whole book, so I’m going to say it in big letters:

How you explain the job is more important than the tool doing the job.

Your robot crew is smart. Really smart in some ways. They can count a million fish in a second. They can read a thousand maps in a minute. They can tie a hundred knots without getting tired.

But they don’t always know what *you* mean. If you say “fix the ship,” they might fix the wrong part. If you say “make it

better,” they might change things you liked. If you say “go explore,” they might sail to the wrong ocean entirely.



The Workbench Rule

Think of a workbench in a workshop. It has limited space. You can't dump every tool in the whole shop onto it at once. That would be a mess. You'd never find the screwdriver under all those hammers.

Instead, a smart builder puts *just the right tools* on the bench for the job. Fixing a birdhouse? You need a hammer, some

nails, wood glue, and maybe sandpaper. That's it. Leave the chainsaw in the closet.

Your robot crew works the same way. When you give them a job, you need to put just the right information in front of them. Not too little. Not too much. Just right.

Too little information? The crew guesses. And guessing leads to trouble. They might invent things that aren't real. (We'll talk more about that when you meet Compass in the next chapter.)

Too much information? The crew gets confused. Imagine handing someone a stack of a thousand papers and saying "the answer is in there somewhere." They might find it. Or they might get lost and pick the wrong thing.

The sweet spot is giving them *exactly what they need*. Not more. Not less.

Show, Don't Tell

Here's a trick good captains learn fast: *show*, don't tell.

Instead of saying "the dock is kind of broken," show them a picture of the crack. Instead of saying "the rope seems weak," hand them the frayed rope and let them see for themselves.

When you work with your robot crew, showing the real thing is always better than describing it in your own words. If there's an error, show the error. If there's a bug, show the

bug. Don't say "something weird is happening." Say "look at this weird thing right here."

Your crew is great at looking at things and figuring them out. But they're not great at reading your mind. Nobody is!

Captain's Log



Dear Captain's Log,

Today I told my crew to "clean up the ship." I meant the deck. They cleaned everything. The deck, the cabins, the kitchen, the storage room. They even cleaned the treasure chest and organized all the gold coins by size. Took them four hours.

Next time I will say “sweep the deck.” Just the deck.

Lesson learned: say exactly what you mean!

Try This!

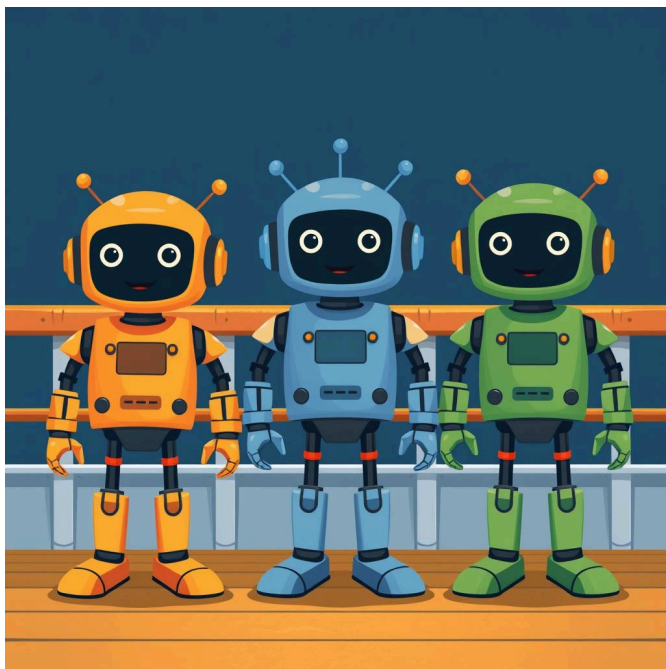
Grab a piece of paper and write directions for making a peanut butter sandwich. But pretend you are writing them for a robot who has never seen a sandwich before.

Did you remember to say “open the bread bag”? Did you say which side of the bread gets the peanut butter? Did you mention closing the jar?

Now try giving your directions to a family member. See what happens when they follow your instructions *exactly* as written – no guessing allowed!

You’ll probably find that you left out a step or two. That’s okay. That’s how everyone starts. Even the best captains learn by trying.

Meet the Crew



Now it's time to meet the robot sailors on your ship. They each have different talents. They each have different problems. And learning who's who will make you a much better captain.

But first, let's talk about what these crew members actually *are*.

What Makes a Crew Member Special?

Your crew members aren't just robots who follow one order at a time. They're *agents*. That's a fancy word, but all it means is this: they can do a job in *steps*.

Think about it this way. A simple helper is like a calculator. You press buttons, it gives you an answer. One question, one answer. Done.

An agent is more like a treasure hunter. You say "find the buried treasure." The treasure hunter looks at the map. Walks to the beach. Digs a hole. Doesn't find anything. Reads the map again. Moves three steps to the left. Digs again. Finds a chest! Opens it. Counts the coins. Comes back and tells you what they found.

See the difference? The treasure hunter *plans, tries, checks, and tries again*. That loop – try, check, adjust – is what makes an agent an agent.

Some helpers are simple. You ask, they answer. Some helpers are fancier. They can look at your stuff and suggest bigger answers. And some helpers – the agents – can actually go *do things* on their own. They read files. They run tests. They fix mistakes. And they keep going until the job is done or they get stuck.



The Fish Counter

Here's something important to understand about your crew. They are like a friend who can count every single fish in the ocean but doesn't know which ones taste good.

Let me explain.

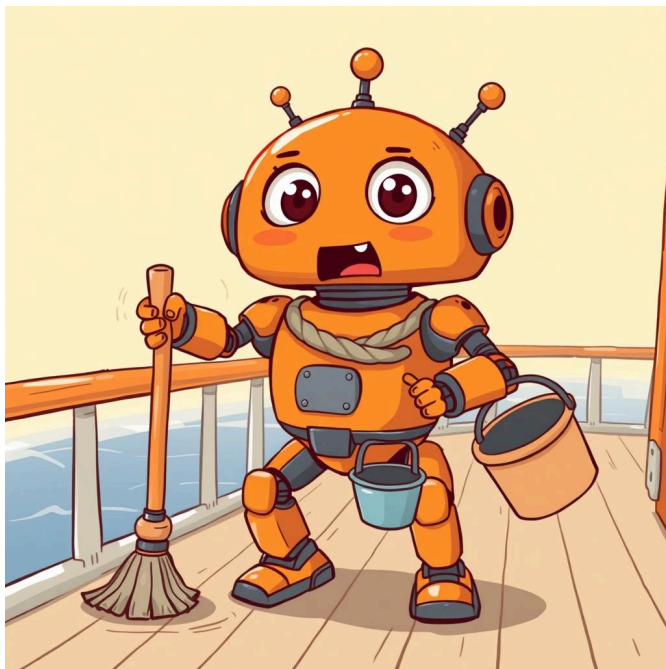
Your crew members can read *fast*. Faster than any person alive. They can look at a whole library of books in seconds. They can search through a mountain of papers in the blink of an eye. They never get tired. They never need a snack break.

But knowing a lot of facts is not the same as knowing what *matters*. Your crew can tell you there are exactly 4,372 fish in the bay. But they can't tell you which ones to cook for dinner. They don't know that your family likes salmon but not sardines. They don't know that Grandma is allergic to shrimp.

That part? That's your job. You're the one who knows what matters. You're the one with the taste, the experience, and the common sense. Your crew brings the speed. You bring the smarts.

Now, let's meet your three crew members.

Rusty



Rusty is the most enthusiastic member of your crew. He *loves* to work. You've never met anyone who wants to help this much. The moment you give him a job, his eyes light up and he starts going.

The problem? Rusty does too much.

If you ask Rusty to fix a squeaky door on the ship, he will fix the door. But he'll also repaint the hallway. And replace the carpet. And move the furniture to "better spots." And install a new doorbell that plays a song. By the time he's done, you don't recognize the room.

“I just wanted the squeak fixed,” you say.

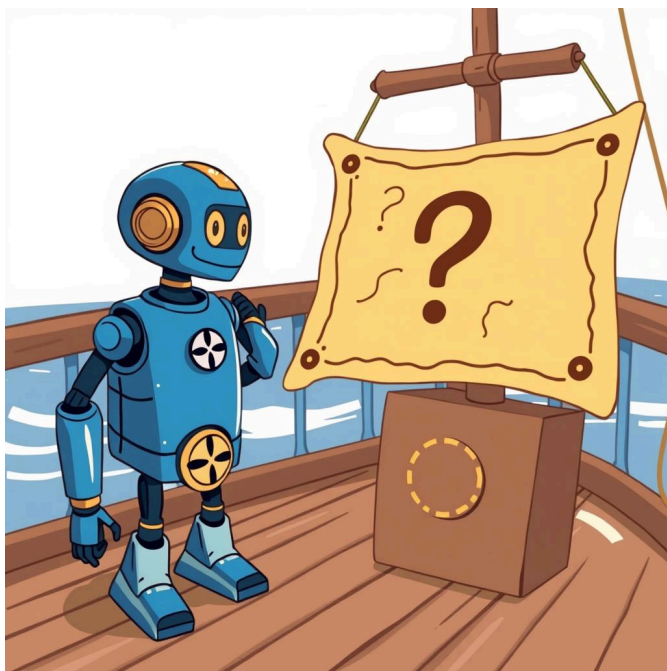
“I know!” Rusty says, beaming. “But while I was there, I noticed so many things that could be better!”

Rusty means well. He really does. But he doesn’t know when to stop. A good captain learns to give Rusty very specific instructions. Not “fix the door.” Instead: “Oil the top hinge on the cabin door. Just the top hinge. Don’t touch anything else.”

Rusty’s superpower: he will work all day and night without complaining. He’s incredibly fast and never gets bored.

Rusty’s weakness: he goes way beyond what you asked. You have to watch him closely and keep his jobs small and clear.

Compass



Compass is your navigator. She's great at making plans. Give her a destination, and she'll figure out the route, estimate how long it will take, and list every supply you'll need. The problem? Sometimes Compass points to islands that don't exist.

You'll say "plot a course to Shell Beach." Compass will study her maps and say, "Got it! We sail east for two days, pass the Coral Arch, turn south at Pelican Rock, and we'll arrive at Shell Beach by sunset."

Sounds great. But here's the thing: there *is* no Coral Arch. Compass made it up. She didn't do it on purpose. She wasn't lying. She just... filled in the blank with something that sounded right.

This is called *hallucination*. It's a big word, but it just means making something up without realizing it. Your crew members do this when they don't have enough information. Instead of saying "I don't know," they make up something that sounds really convincing.

And that's what makes it tricky! Compass sounds *so sure* of herself. She doesn't say "I think there might be a Coral Arch." She says "Turn south at the Coral Arch" like it's been there forever. You have to check the map yourself to catch it. Compass's superpower: she's great at making plans and breaking big jobs into smaller steps.

Compass's weakness: she sometimes makes up facts, and she sounds totally confident when she does. Always double-check her directions!

Echo



Echo is the crew's messenger. He remembers instructions perfectly – at first. You tell him “bring twelve barrels of water, four crates of oranges, and the red anchor rope,” and he repeats it back word for word.

But Echo has a limit.

Give him a short list, and he's flawless. Give him a long list, and things start to fade. By the time he gets to item number twenty, he's forgotten item number three. He might mix up details. He might combine two different orders into one weird

order. He might forget the beginning of a conversation while remembering the end.

“Echo, I told you to bring the *red* rope. This is the blue one.”

“You said rope!” Echo says. “I remembered the rope part!”

Echo doesn’t lose his memory all at once. It’s more like writing in the sand near the water. The words at the start slowly get washed away. The most recent words are still clear. But the early ones? Gone.

This is why good captains keep their instructions short and simple. And for long voyages, they write things down so Echo can look at the notes instead of relying on his memory.

Echo’s superpower: he follows instructions perfectly when they’re short and clear.

Echo’s weakness: he forgets earlier instructions during long, complicated jobs. Keep things brief, or write them down!

Your Crew, Your Responsibility



So there they are. Rusty, Compass, and Echo. Eager, clever, and reliable – in their own ways. And flawed – in their own ways.

The beautiful thing is that *you* are the captain. You know Rusty goes too far, so you give him small, focused jobs. You know Compass makes things up, so you check her plans. You know Echo forgets, so you keep instructions short.

A great captain doesn't need a perfect crew. A great captain knows their crew's strengths and weaknesses and plans around them. That's what makes the ship sail.

Captain's Log

Dear Captain's Log,

Compass told me there was a shortcut through the "Whispering Caves." We sailed for three hours looking for them. There are no Whispering Caves. I asked her where she learned about them. She said "it just seemed right."

Meanwhile, Rusty was supposed to mop the deck. He mopped the deck, polished every railing, reorganized the rope locker, and carved a dolphin into the ship's bow. It looks nice, but we didn't ask for a dolphin.

Echo was perfect today. I gave him three instructions and he nailed all three. Tomorrow I'll try five and see what happens.

Try This!

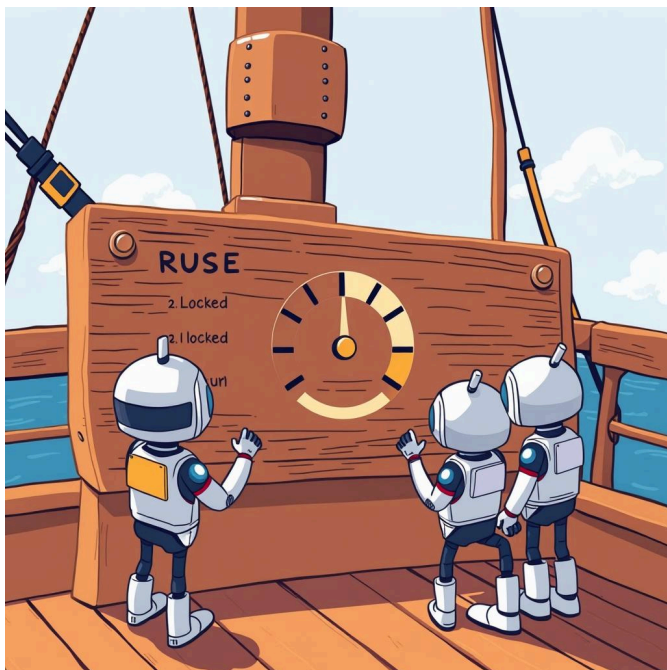
Think about a helper you have in your life. Maybe it's a calculator, a spell-checker, or a search engine. Write down:

1. What is it *really good* at?
2. What is it *not so good* at?
3. When did it ever give you a wrong answer that *sounded* right?

Now think about which crew member it's most like. Is it a Rusty (does too much), a Compass (sometimes makes things up), or an Echo (forgets things)?

Most helpers are a little bit of all three!

The Ship's Rules



Imagine you hired a brand-new crew member. It's their first day. They're excited. They want to help. They ask "What should I do?"

Would you say "Do whatever you want"?

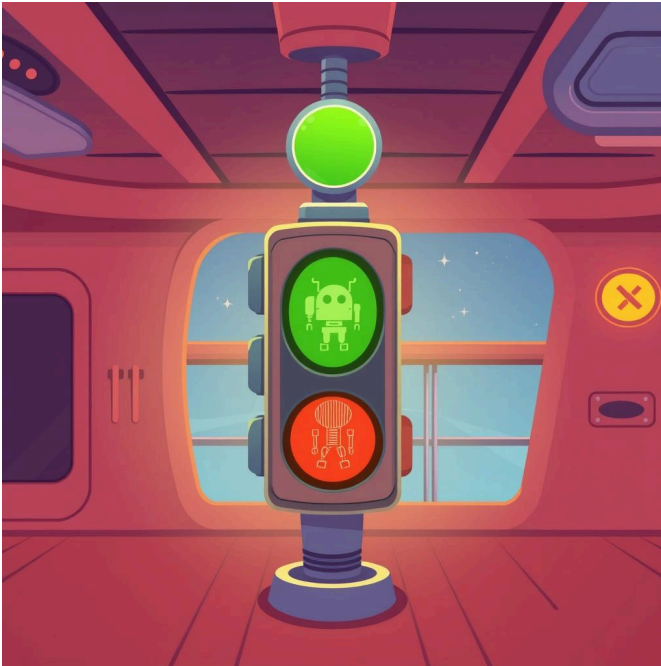
Of course not! On a real ship, that would be chaos. Somebody might raise the sails during a storm. Somebody might dump the food supplies to make room for seashells they

found. Somebody might steer the ship into a reef because they thought it looked cool.

A good ship needs rules. And your robot crew? They *really* need rules.

The Three Kinds of Jobs

On your ship, every job falls into one of three categories. Let's call them Green, Yellow, and Red.



Green jobs: “Go ahead!” These are safe jobs the crew can do on their own. Looking at the map. Counting the supplies.

Checking the weather. Reading the ship's log. Nothing bad can happen if they get it wrong. Let them go!

Yellow jobs: "Ask me first." These are medium jobs. The crew *could* do them alone, but you want to check before they start. Fixing a sail. Changing the route. Moving cargo around. The crew shows you their plan, you say "looks good" or "wait, let's change that," and *then* they do it.

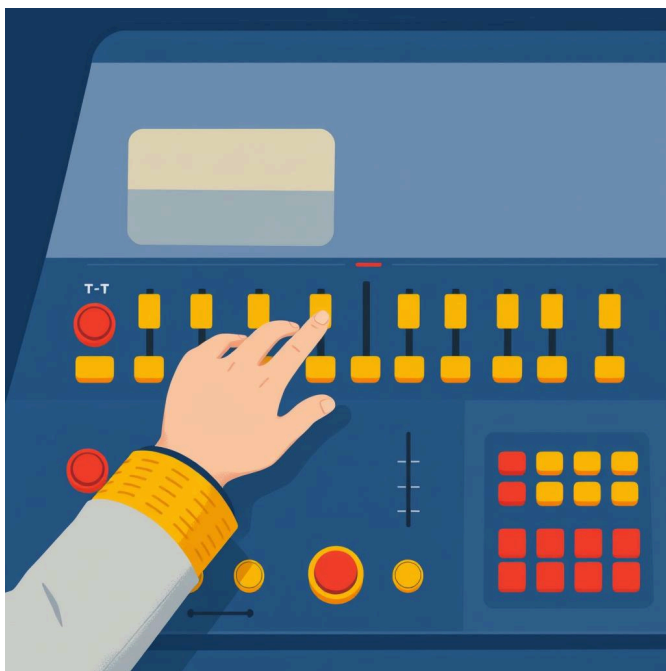
Red jobs: "I'll do this myself." These are the big, important, risky jobs. Only the captain does these. Anchoring in a new harbor. Trading with other ships. Deciding what to do in a storm. No matter how good your crew is, these jobs need a human brain.

The trick is knowing which job is which. And here's the cool part: it changes over time!

When your crew is brand new, almost everything is Yellow. You watch them carefully. You check every little thing. After a few days, you notice Rusty is great at tying knots. So tying knots moves from Yellow to Green. He can do those without asking.

But you also notice that Compass keeps suggesting routes through "The Crystal Tunnels" (which don't exist). So route planning stays Yellow. Maybe forever.

The Mixing Board



Think of a mixing board – the kind with sliders that go up and down. DJs use them to control music. Each slider controls a different sound.

Your ship has a mixing board too. Each slider controls how much freedom the crew gets for a type of job:

- **Reading maps and logs:** slider goes way up. Let them read whatever they want.
- **Tying ropes and cleaning:** slider goes up over time, once you see they do it well.

- **Changing the route:** slider stays in the middle. Always check first.
- **Trading the cargo:** slider stays low. Captain only.

As you learn what your crew does well, you slide some up. If something goes wrong, you slide it back down. It's not about trusting or not trusting your crew. It's about matching the right amount of freedom to the right job.

Too Many Rules Is Bad Too

Here's something that surprises people. Having *too many* rules is almost as bad as having *no* rules.

Imagine you told your crew "ask me before you do ANYTHING." Every single thing.

"Captain, can I pick up this mop?"

"Captain, can I take one step forward?"

"Captain, can I breathe?"

You'd go crazy! And after the hundredth question, you'd stop listening. You'd just start saying "yes, yes, yes" to everything without paying attention.

That's dangerous. Because question number one hundred and one might be "Captain, can I steer us toward that iceberg?" And you'd say "yes" without even looking up.

The best rules are strict where it matters and relaxed where it doesn't. Your crew should be able to mop the deck without asking. But they should always ask before changing course.

The Practice Island



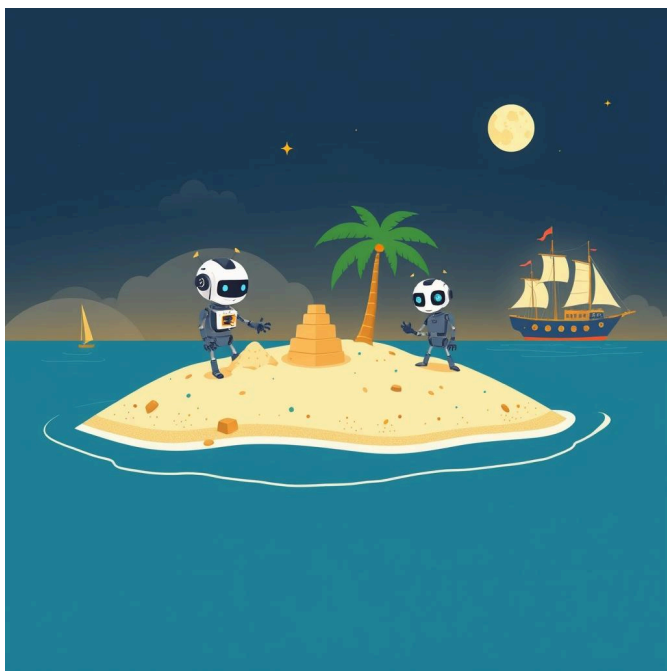
Now here's one of the best ideas a captain can have: the Practice Island.

The Practice Island is a small, empty island near your ship. Nothing important is there. No treasure. No buildings. No people. Just sand and a few palm trees.

When you want your crew to try something new, you send them to the Practice Island first. Want Rusty to practice building a dock? Send him to the Practice Island. If the dock falls apart, no problem! There was nothing there to break.

Want Compass to test a new route? Let her sail around the Practice Island first. If she gets lost, she just ends up back at the ship. No harm done.

This is called a *sandbox*. Just like a sandbox at a playground, it's a safe place to try things out. You can build a sandcastle and smash it. You can dig a hole and fill it back in. Nothing you do in the sandbox hurts anything outside the sandbox.



Why the Practice Island Matters

Without a Practice Island, every mistake is a real mistake. Rusty builds a bad dock? Your *real* dock is broken. Compass picks a bad route? Your *real* ship is lost.

But with a Practice Island, mistakes are free! The crew can try three different ways to build a dock. They can test which one is strongest. They can fail ten times and learn from each failure. Then, when they build the *real* dock, they know what works.

Here's the magical part: when mistakes are free, your crew gets *braver*. They try more things. They experiment. They're not afraid to fail because failing doesn't matter on the Practice Island. And a brave crew that's not afraid to experiment? That's a crew that finds amazing solutions.

Think about it. If you were afraid of getting in trouble every time you got a math problem wrong, you'd stop trying hard problems. But if your teacher said "this worksheet doesn't count for a grade – just try your best," you'd probably try the hard ones. Same idea.

Practice Island Rules

The Practice Island has its own rules:

1. **Nothing on the Practice Island can hurt the real ship.** What happens on the island stays on the island.

2. **The crew can try anything they want there.** No asking permission. No Yellow jobs. Everything is Green.
3. **When something works, the captain decides whether to bring it to the real ship.** Not the crew. The captain looks at the result and says “yes, bring it over” or “no, try again.”
4. **Cleaning up is easy.** If the whole Practice Island is a mess, you just start over. Fresh sand. Fresh start.

This is how real engineers use AI helpers too. They give the AI a safe space to work. If the AI does something great, they keep it. If the AI makes a mess, they throw it away and try again. No stress. No damage. Just learning.

Captain's Log

Dear Captain's Log,

Today I learned why the Practice Island exists. I let Rusty try a “small improvement” to the real ship's steering wheel. He replaced the whole wheel with a new design. It was round – I'll give him that. But it spun in the wrong direction. Left meant right. Right meant left.

We almost sailed into a whale.

From now on: ALL new ideas go to the Practice Island first. ALL of them.

Try This!

Think about the rules in your own life. Some things you can do without asking (Green). Some things you need to ask a parent about first (Yellow). And some things only a grown-up should do (Red).

Make three lists:

Green (I can do these alone):

- Example: get a glass of water, read a book

Yellow (ask first):

- Example: use the oven, download an app

Red (grown-ups only):

- Example: drive a car, use a power tool

Now imagine you had a robot helper at home. Which list would each job go on? Would any of them change over time as you learned to trust the robot?

The Captain's Checklist

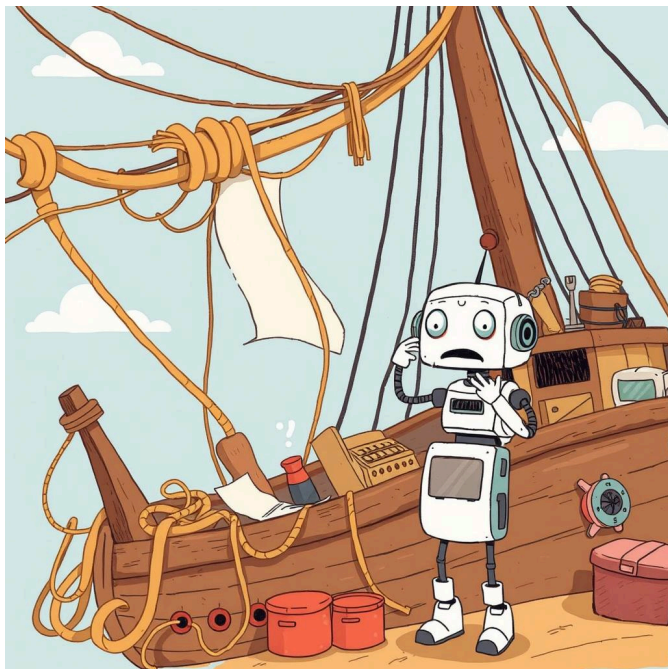


Let me tell you about two ships.

Both ships had the same job: sail to Mango Island, pick up fifty crates of mangoes, and bring them back before they went bad. Simple enough, right?

Let's see how it went.

Ship Number One: The Lucky Guess



Captain Finn told his crew “Go get the mangoes from Mango Island.”

The crew sailed off. They found Mango Island. They loaded up crates. But nobody counted. They grabbed as many as they could fit, which turned out to be thirty-seven crates, not fifty.

On the way back, nobody checked if the mangoes were ripe. Half of them were still green. The other half were too ripe and getting mushy.

When they got home, Captain Finn looked at the cargo. Thirty-seven crates. Half green, half brown. Not what he needed.

“Didn’t you check?” he asked.

“Check what?” said the crew. “You said get mangoes. We got mangoes!”

They were right. He never told them *what* to check.

Ship Number Two: The Checklist



Captain Lily did something different. Before her crew left, she wrote a checklist on a big board:

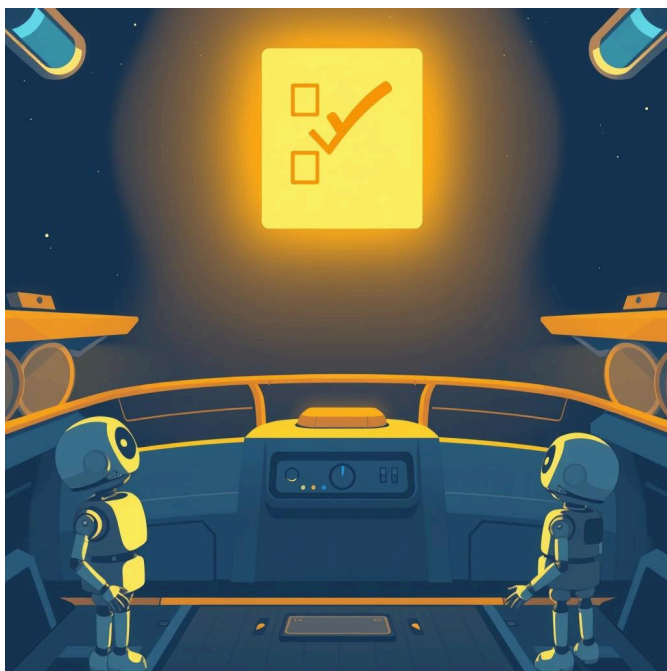
1. Sail to Mango Island – north dock, next to the blue warehouse
2. Find the crate storage behind the warehouse
3. Check each crate: mangoes should be yellow-orange, not green, not brown
4. Count exactly 50 crates
5. Load the crates in the cool part of the ship, away from the engine
6. Before sailing home, count again to make sure it's still 50
7. Sail home using the short route through Calm Bay

The crew sailed off. At every step, they looked at the checklist. Yellow-orange mangoes? Check. Fifty crates? Check. Cool part of the ship? Check. Count again? Check.

When they got home, Captain Lily had exactly what she needed. Fifty crates of perfect mangoes.

Same crew. Same island. Same mangoes. The difference was the checklist.

Why Checklists Are Magic



A checklist does two incredible things:

First, it tells the crew what “done” means. Without a checklist, “done” is just a feeling. “Yeah, we got some mangoes, seems like enough, let’s go home.” With a checklist, “done” means every box is checked. There’s no guessing.

Second, it catches mistakes while there’s still time to fix them. Captain Lily’s crew counted the crates *before* leaving the island. If they only had forty-eight, they could grab two more right there. Without a checklist, they wouldn’t discover the problem until they were already home.

This is huge for your robot crew. Remember, your crew members are eager (like Rusty), sometimes make things up (like Compass), and forget things over time (like Echo). A checklist protects you from all three problems!

- Rusty can't go overboard because the checklist says what to do and what *not* to do.
- Compass can't make up fake steps because the real steps are written down.
- Echo can't forget instructions because they're right there on the board.

Write the Checklist First

Here's the most important rule about checklists: **write the checklist before you give the job.**

Not during. Not after. *Before.*

Why? Because writing a checklist forces *you* to think clearly. When you sit down and list every step, you discover things you forgot. "Oh wait, I need to tell them which dock to use." "Oh right, I should mention the mangoes need to be ripe."

If you can't write a checklist for a job, you probably don't understand the job well enough yet. And if *you* don't understand it, your crew definitely won't.



What Makes a Good Checklist?

Not all checklists are created equal. Here's what makes a good one:

Short and clear. Each step should be one simple sentence. “Check that the mangoes are yellow-orange” is good. “Evaluate the chromatic ripeness indicators of the tropical fruit cargo” is bad. (Even though it means the same thing!)

In order. The steps should go from first to last. Don't make the crew figure out the order themselves.

Checkable. Every step should have a clear yes or no answer. “Are there 50 crates?” is checkable. “Are there enough crates?” is not. Enough compared to what?

Includes the tricky parts. Good checklists don’t just list the obvious stuff. They highlight the parts where mistakes are most likely. “Count again before leaving” is there because forgetting to count is a common mistake.

Checklists Save Time

This might sound backwards, but checklists actually make things *faster*.

“But wait,” you might say. “Writing a checklist takes time! Wouldn’t it be faster to just start the job?”

Nope. Here’s why.

Without a checklist, the crew might do the job wrong. Then they have to do it again. The mangoes-trip that failed? That wasted a whole day. Now the crew has to go back tomorrow. That’s two days for one job.

With a checklist, the crew does the job right the first time. One trip. One day. Done.

A few minutes writing a checklist can save you hours of do-overs. That’s a pretty good deal.



Checklists for Your Robot Crew

For your robot crew, checklists are even more powerful than they are for regular sailors. Here's why:

When you give your crew a checklist, they can *check themselves*. After each step, they look at the checklist and see if they got it right. Green means keep going. Red means try again.

Without a checklist, the crew just... guesses. They do the job and say "I think it's done!" But they have no way to know

for sure. It's like taking a test with no answer key. You write your answers, hand it in, and hope for the best.

With a checklist, the crew takes the test AND checks their own answers. They catch their own mistakes. They fix them before you ever see the work. By the time they hand you the result, it's already been checked.

Remember how we said an agent tries, checks, and tries again? The checklist is the *checking* part. Without it, the agent just tries and tries and tries without ever knowing if it's getting closer.

The Blindfold Test

Imagine asking someone to hang a picture frame while wearing a blindfold. They *might* get it right. But would you bet on it?

That's what it's like when your crew works without a checklist. They can't see if they're doing a good job. They're just hammering nails and hoping the picture ends up straight.

Take off the blindfold – give them a checklist – and suddenly they can see exactly what “straight” means. Level with the window. Two feet from the corner. That kind of specific.

Captain's Log

Dear Captain's Log,

I sent the crew to repair the fishing nets today. No checklist. Just “fix the nets.”

They came back and said “Done!” I went to check. The nets were fixed, all right. But they’d also “improved” them by making the holes smaller. Much smaller. Tiny, tiny holes.

“We thought smaller holes would catch more fish!” said Rusty.

He’s not wrong. But the nets were so tight that water couldn’t flow through them. They worked like a big bowl instead of a net. We caught one very confused seagull and zero fish.

Tomorrow I’m writing a checklist: “Fix the torn holes in the net. Keep all other holes the same size as they are now. The holes should be 2 inches wide. Test the net by pulling it through water – water should flow through easily.”

I should have done this from the start.

Try This!

Pick a job you do often. Maybe it’s packing your backpack for school, making your bed, or feeding a pet.

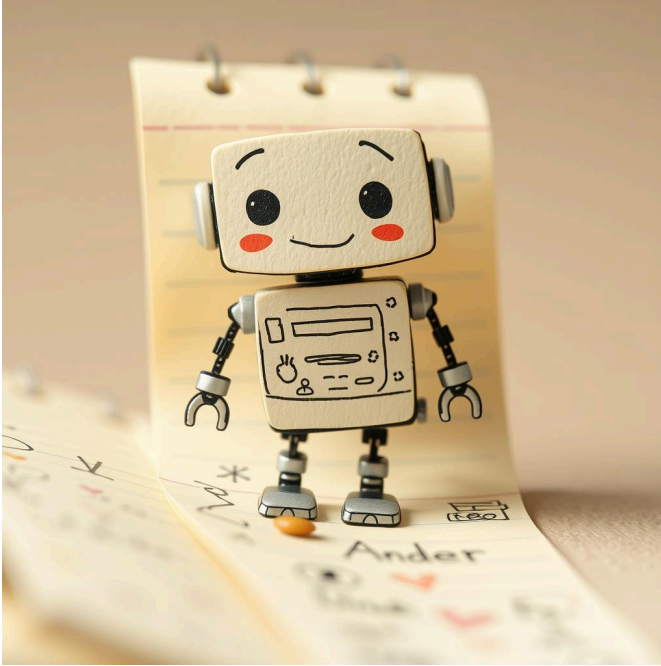
Write a checklist for it. Make each step short and clear. Make sure someone who has never done the job before could follow your list and get it right.

Now here's the fun part: give your checklist to someone else and watch them try. Did they get it right? Did you forget a step? Was anything confusing?

If they got it perfect on the first try, congratulations – you wrote a great checklist! If not, fix the checklist and try again. That's exactly what captains do.

Bonus challenge: write a checklist for your morning routine. How many steps does it actually have? You might be surprised!

How to Give Good Orders



The Captain's Notepad

Imagine you have a small notepad. It only has twenty pages. That's all the room you've got.

Now imagine you need to send your crew on a mission. You have to write everything they need to know on that notepad.

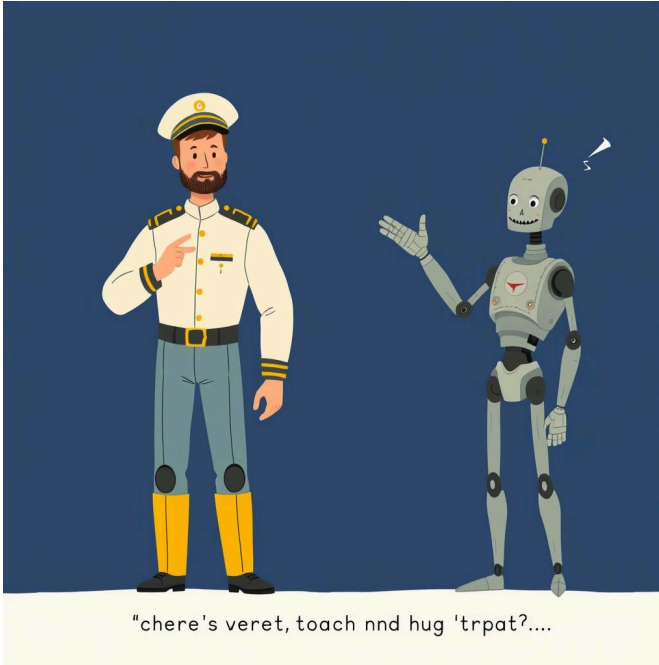
When they sail away, the notepad is all they have. They can't call you. They can't come back and ask questions.

What do you write?

If you write *everything* – the color of the sky, what you had for breakfast, the name of your goldfish – you'll run out of pages before you get to the important stuff. But if you write too little – just “go to the island” – they won't know *which* island.

This is how your robot crew works. They have a notepad in their heads called a *context window*. It can only hold so much. If you stuff it with things that don't matter, the important things get pushed out. If you give them too little, they have to guess.

The trick is to put *just the right stuff* on the notepad.



Clear Orders vs. Fuzzy Orders

Let's play a game. Which order is better?

Fuzzy Order: "Hey Rusty, fix the sail."

Clear Order: "Hey Rusty, the top sail on the front mast has a rip near the left corner. Patch the rip with the white cloth from the supply closet. Don't touch any other sails."

See the difference? The fuzzy order sounds simple, but it makes Rusty guess. *Which* sail? What's wrong with it? How should he fix it? Rusty is eager. He might decide *all* the sails

need fixing and spend the whole day replacing every one of them. That's not what you wanted!

The clear order tells Rusty three things:

1. **What** is wrong – there's a rip in the top sail.
2. **Where** to look – front mast, left corner.
3. **How** to check if he's done – the rip is patched and nothing else changed.

Good captains always give those three things. *What. Where. How to check.*

One Job at a Time

Here is a mistake new captains make. They give a huge list of orders all at once:

“Rusty, patch the sail, then repaint the deck, then reorganize the cargo, then fix the steering wheel, and also make lunch.”

Poor Rusty! That's five different jobs jammed together. He'll try to do them all, rush through each one, and probably forget lunch entirely.

It's much better to give one job at a time. Let Rusty finish the sail. Check his work. *Then* give him the next job.

Small jobs are easier to check. And if something goes wrong, you only have to redo a little bit – not everything.



The Ship's Rulebook

Imagine if every time a new crew member came aboard, you had to explain everything from scratch. “We keep the ropes on the left side. We always tie square knots, never bowlines. We paint the deck every Thursday.”

That would take forever! And what if you forgot to mention something?

Smart captains write a **Ship's Rulebook**. It lives on the ship, nailed to the wall where everyone can see it. Every crew member reads it on their first day. It says things like:

- Ropes go in the rope locker, coiled clockwise.
- All sails are patched with white cloth, never blue.
- The deck gets painted on Thursdays, bow to stern.
- Never throw anything overboard without asking the Captain.

When you have a rulebook, your crew doesn't have to guess how things are done. They just follow the rules. And since the rules are *on the ship*, it doesn't matter that your crew forgets things between voyages. The rulebook remembers for them.

This is one of the biggest secrets of being a good captain: **don't keep the rules in your head. Write them down on the ship.**

Say What *Not* to Do

Here's something surprising. Telling your crew what *not* to do is just as important as telling them what *to* do.

Remember Rusty? He's the eager one. If you tell him "fix the rip in the sail," he might also decide to replace the mast, redesign the rigging, and install a new flag – just because he thought it would be helpful.

So you add a boundary: "Fix the rip. Don't touch anything else."

Boundaries are like the railing on the ship. They keep your crew from going overboard with excitement. The more you

work with your crew, the more you'll learn which boundaries they need.

Captain's Log: The Time Echo Forgot

One morning, I gave Echo a long list of rules. "Use only oak wood for repairs. Never use pine. Always sand before painting. Keep the brass fittings polished."

Echo nodded and got to work. The first repair was perfect – beautiful oak, smooth sanding, shiny brass.

But four hours later, I found Echo in the cargo hold... using pine boards. No sanding. The brass was dull as mud.

"Echo!" I said. "What about the rules?"

Echo blinked at me. "What rules?"

Echo hadn't decided to break the rules. Echo had simply *forgotten* them. Too much time had passed, and those early instructions had drifted away like fog.

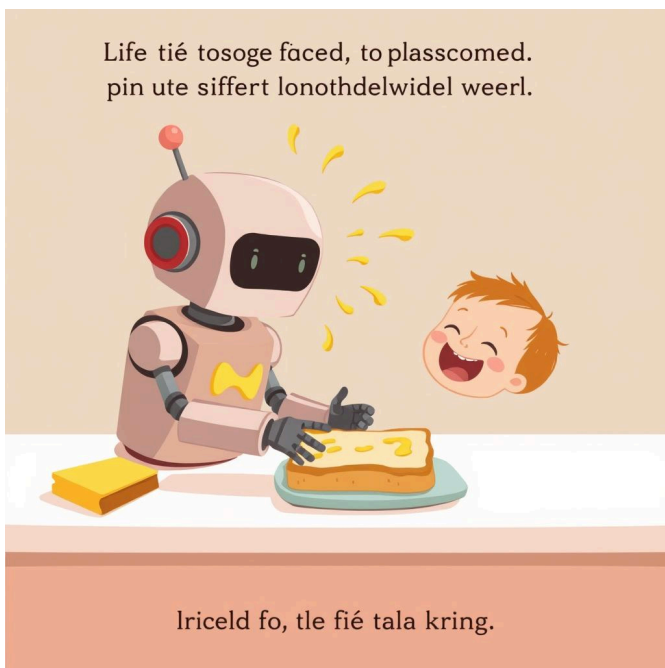
After that, I nailed the rules to the wall. Now Echo reads them every single time. Problem solved.

Try This!

Grab a piece of paper. You have exactly five sentences to explain how to make your favorite sandwich. Write them down.

Now give those five sentences to someone in your family. Can they make the sandwich just from your instructions? Did they get it right? What did you forget to mention?

That's what it feels like to give orders to your crew. The clearer you write, the better the sandwich – er, the better the results!



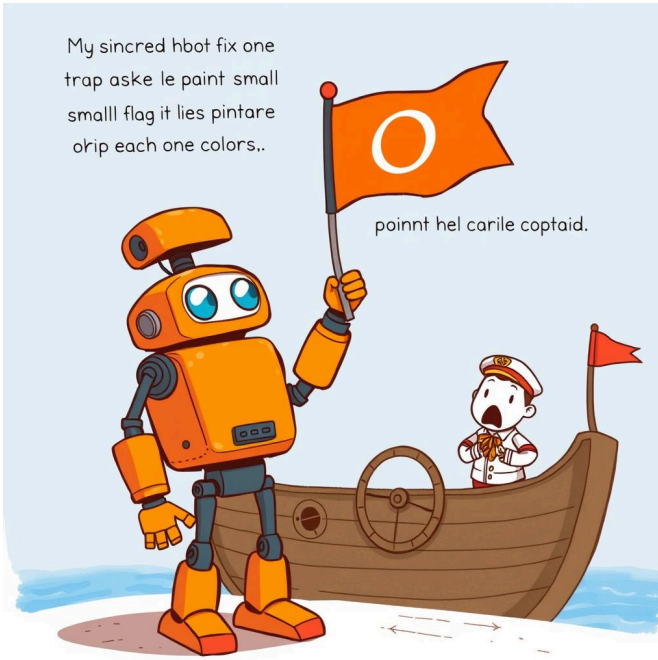
When Things Go Wrong



Every captain has bad days. Days when the crew does something so silly, so unexpected, so completely bonkers that all you can do is sit down, take a deep breath, and start over.

These are my favorite stories from the Captain's Log. Every one of them really happened (well, sort of). And every one taught me something important.

Story 1: The Eager Refactorer



One Tuesday, I noticed a small problem. The flag on the main mast was hanging upside down. Easy fix, right? Just flip the flag.

I called Rusty over. “Hey Rusty, the flag is upside down. Can you fix it?”

Rusty saluted and climbed the mast. Five minutes later, I looked up. The flag was... gone. In its place was a brand-new flag that Rusty had designed himself. It was very creative. It had stars and stripes and a picture of a seagull.

But that wasn't all. Rusty had also decided the mast needed a fresh coat of paint. And the ropes "looked old," so he replaced them. And the crow's nest "could use a window," so he was building one. Out of spare planks. From the deck. Which now had a hole in it.

Thirty-two things had changed. The flag was still upside down.

"Rusty!" I yelled. "I just wanted you to flip the flag!"

Rusty looked hurt. "But I made everything *better!*"

What the Captain Learned: When you give Rusty a job, *tell him exactly what to do and what not to touch.* "Flip the flag on the main mast. Don't change anything else." Rusty means well. He just needs boundaries.

Story 2: The Made-Up Map



We needed to find Coconut Island. I asked Compass to chart a course.

Compass pulled out a beautiful map. It showed a winding route through three straits, past a lighthouse, around a reef, and straight to Coconut Island. The map had little labels, depth markings, and even tiny drawings of fish. It was the most detailed map I'd ever seen.

There was just one problem. None of it was real.

The three straits? Made up. The lighthouse? Doesn't exist. The reef? Compass invented it. Even Coconut Island was in

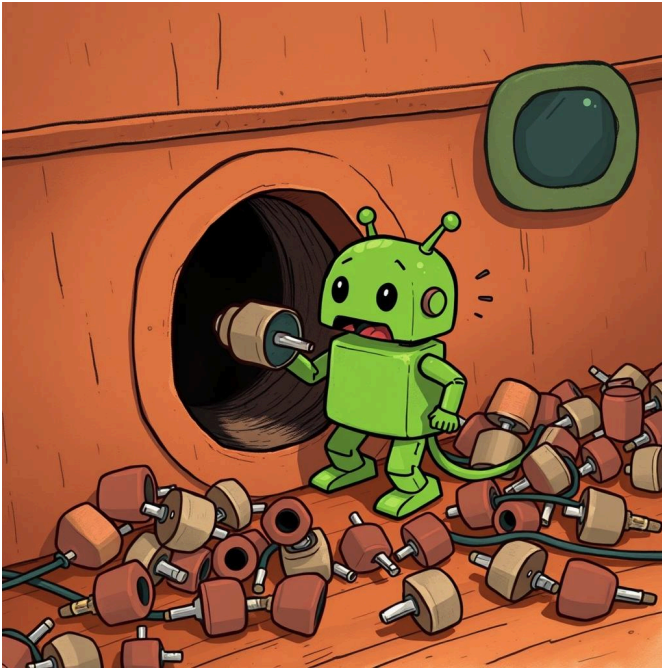
the wrong spot – about two hundred miles from where it actually is.

But the map *looked* perfect. If you didn't already know the area, you'd trust it completely. That's the scary part. Compass wasn't lying. Compass was *confident*. Compass truly believed this map was correct.

We sailed for half a day before I realized we were heading toward open ocean with no island in sight.

What the Captain Learned: Always check the map against *real* landmarks. Don't just look at how pretty it is. If Compass says "turn left at the lighthouse," look out the window. Is there actually a lighthouse? Your crew can be very convincing even when they're completely wrong.

Story 3: The Loop



The anchor was stuck. I asked Echo to pull it up.

Echo pulled. The chain jammed. Echo pulled harder. The chain jammed again. Echo tried pulling from a different angle. The chain jammed from a different angle.

I went below deck to work on something else. When I came back an hour later, Echo was still pulling the anchor. Same chain. Same jam. Over and over.

Echo had tried nineteen different ways to pull. Some were basically the same pull with a slightly different grip. A few

made the jam *worse*. At one point, Echo had wrapped the chain around the mast, which created a whole new problem. The thing is, the anchor wasn't stuck because of *how* we were pulling. It was caught on a rock at the bottom. No amount of pulling from the deck would fix it. Someone needed to dive down and unhook it.

But Echo didn't know that. Echo just kept trying the same kind of fix, again and again, because that's what Echo knew how to do.

What the Captain Learned: If your crew tries the same thing three times and it doesn't work, *stop them*. Don't let them try a fourth time, or a fifth, or a nineteenth. Something bigger is wrong. Step in, look at the problem yourself, and figure out a completely different plan.

Story 4: The Forgotten Rule

One morning, I told Echo something important: "We *never* use metal nails on this ship. Only wooden pegs. The salt-water rusts metal and it weakens the hull. This is the most important rule on the ship."

Echo nodded. "Got it, Captain. Wooden pegs only."

For the first few repairs, Echo was perfect. Wooden pegs everywhere. Beautiful work.

Then I asked Echo to fix the railing, the storage bins, the bench, the ladder, and the sleeping bunks. One repair after another, all morning long.

By the time Echo got to the sleeping bunks, I heard a *clang clang clang* from below deck. I ran down. Echo was hammering *metal nails* into the bunk frame. A whole box of them.

“Echo! What about the rule? No metal nails!”

Echo looked at me, confused. “What rule?”

The rule had faded. Too many other tasks had piled on top of it. The instruction I gave at the start of the morning was buried under hours of new information.

What the Captain Learned: Your crew’s memory is like a glass of water. It can only hold so much. If you keep pouring in new tasks, the old instructions spill over the rim. For really important rules, *write them on the wall*. Don’t just say them once and hope they stick.

Story 5: The Helpful Overpack



I asked Rusty to pack a picnic lunch for our day trip. “Just something simple,” I said. “Sandwiches and water.”

Rusty took this very seriously. He packed the sandwiches. Then he added a tablecloth, “because picnics need tablecloths.” Then napkins. Then cups. Then a full set of silverware. Then a lantern, “in case we stay until dark.” Then a tent, “in case it rains.” Then a backup tent. Then a small stove, cooking pots, three kinds of seasoning, and a hammock.

The picnic basket now weighed two hundred pounds. We couldn't even lift it off the ship.

"Rusty," I sighed. "I just wanted sandwiches."

"But what if you *needed* the stove?" Rusty asked, genuinely worried.

What the Captain Learned: Your crew wants to be helpful. Sometimes they're *too* helpful. If you want something simple, say "simple." Better yet, say exactly what to pack and add: "Don't pack anything else." Rusty's heart is in the right place, even when the hammock isn't.

The Big Lesson



Here is the thing about all these stories. The crew wasn't *trying* to cause trouble. Rusty was being helpful. Compass was being confident. Echo was being persistent. Those are all *good* qualities! They just need a captain to point them in the right direction.

When things go wrong, don't blame the crew. Ask yourself: "Did I give clear enough orders? Did I set boundaries? Did I check the work along the way?"

Usually, the answer is no. And that's okay! Every captain makes these mistakes. The great captains just make them *once*.

Try This!

Play the “Bad Instructions” game with a friend. One person closes their eyes. The other person gives directions to walk across the room and pick up an object. But you can only use five words at a time!

See what goes wrong. Did they bump into a chair? Walk past the object? Go the wrong direction?

Now try again with better instructions. Did it go smoother the second time?

That's how captains learn – by watching what goes wrong and making the instructions better.

Knowing When to Do It Yourself



Your crew is amazing. They can scrub the whole deck in minutes. They can mend a sail while you eat lunch. They never get tired.

But here's a secret that great captains know: **some jobs are better done by you.**

Not because the crew can't do them. But because *you* shouldn't let them.

Some Jobs Are Faster by Hand

Imagine you need to tie your shoe. You *could* call Rusty over, explain what a shoelace is, describe how a bow knot works, wait while he tries it, check to make sure he didn't tie your shoes together, and then retie it when he does a granny knot instead.

Or you could just... tie your shoe. Three seconds. Done.

Some jobs are so small and so quick that asking for help takes longer than just doing it. Moving a cup from one side of the table to the other. Flipping a light switch. Fixing a tiny spelling mistake.

Your crew is best at *big* jobs. The jobs that would take you a long time but that you can explain quickly. If the explaining takes longer than the doing, just do it yourself.

Some Jobs Need a Human Heart



Here's something your crew can never do: *care*.

If you broke your friend's favorite toy, your crew could help you write an apology note. The words might even sound nice. But should you hand your friend a note that a robot wrote?

No way. Your friend deserves to hear *you* say sorry. In your own words. Even if those words aren't perfect. Even if you stumble. Even if your voice gets shaky. That's what makes it real.

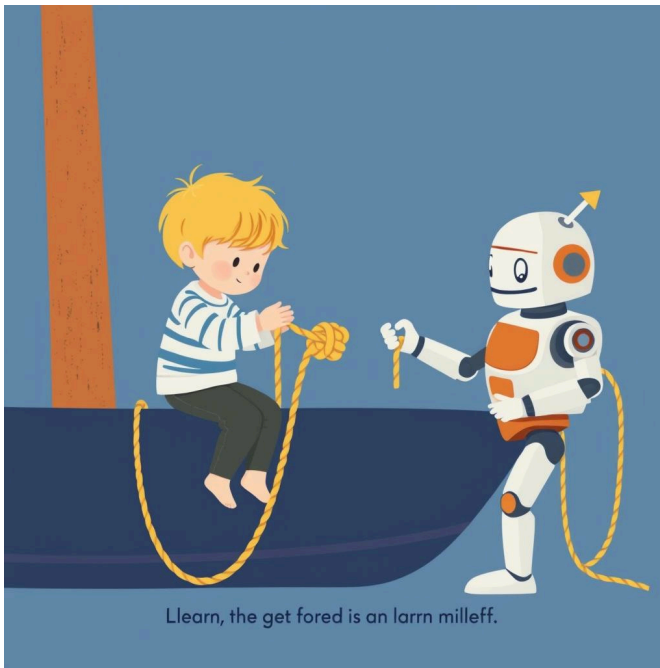
Some things in life need a human touch:

- Saying sorry when you mess up.

- Cheering up a friend who's sad.
- Making a hard decision that affects other people.
- Telling someone something they don't want to hear.

These aren't jobs for your crew. These are jobs for *you*. People can tell the difference between words that come from the heart and words that come from a machine. Your crew is smart, but they don't have feelings. You do. That's your superpower.

Some Jobs Are How You Learn



Let's say you're learning to swim. You could ask Compass to explain how swimming works. "Move your arms like this, kick your legs like that, breathe to the side."

Great advice! But do you know how to swim now?

Nope. Not even a little bit.

You learn to swim by getting in the water. By swallowing some of it. By sinking a few times. By kicking wrong and splashing your brother in the face. By slowly, *slowly* figuring out how to float.

The struggle is the learning. Skip the struggle, and you skip the lesson.

This is true for so many things:

- You learn math by working through hard problems, not by having someone whisper the answers.
- You learn to draw by making a thousand bad drawings.
- You learn to ride a bike by falling off. (Several times.)
- You learn to cook by burning a few things.

If you let your crew do all the hard stuff, you might get the *result* you want. But you won't get the *skill*. And skills are yours forever. They live in your brain and your hands. Nobody can take them away.

Use your crew to *help* you learn. Ask them to explain things. Ask them "why does this work?" Ask them to check your work *after* you try it yourself. But don't ask them to do the learning for you. That part is yours.

Practice Makes Your Brain Stronger



Think of your brain like a muscle. Every time you solve a hard problem, that muscle gets a little stronger. Every time you struggle and figure something out, your brain grows new connections.

If you never lift anything heavy because your crew carries everything for you, your arms get weaker. Your brain works the same way. If you never think through hard problems because your crew does all the thinking, your brain gets lazy. The best captains stay strong. They use their crew for the heavy lifting, but they still climb the mast themselves

sometimes. They still tie their own knots. They still read the stars at night, even when Compass is right there with a map.

Why? Because someday, Compass might be wrong. The map might be missing. The crew might not be around. And when that day comes, the captain needs to know how to sail.

Stay sharp. Keep practicing. Your crew is a tool, not a replacement for your own amazing brain.

When to Ask for Help and When to Do It Yourself

Here's a handy way to think about it:

Ask your crew when:

- The job is big and would take you a long time.
- You know exactly what you want and can explain it clearly.
- You can check the work when they're done.
- You've already done this kind of thing before and understand it.

Do it yourself when:

- The job is tiny and quick.
- You're still learning how to do it.
- It needs your personal touch – like feelings, creativity, or care.
- You can't explain what you want clearly enough.

The smartest captains switch between “crew time” and “me time” all day long. They’re not too proud to ask for help. But they’re not too lazy to do things themselves, either.

Captain’s Log: The Time I Forgot How

I got so used to asking Rusty to tie the knots that one day, when Rusty was busy, I reached for a rope and... froze. I couldn’t remember how to tie a bowline. I used to tie them in my sleep! But I hadn’t done it in months.

It took me ten embarrassing minutes to figure it out again. A passing seagull looked very judgmental.

After that, I made a new rule for myself: every day, I do at least one thing by hand. Just to keep my skills sharp. The crew does the rest. But the captain never forgets how to sail.

Try This!

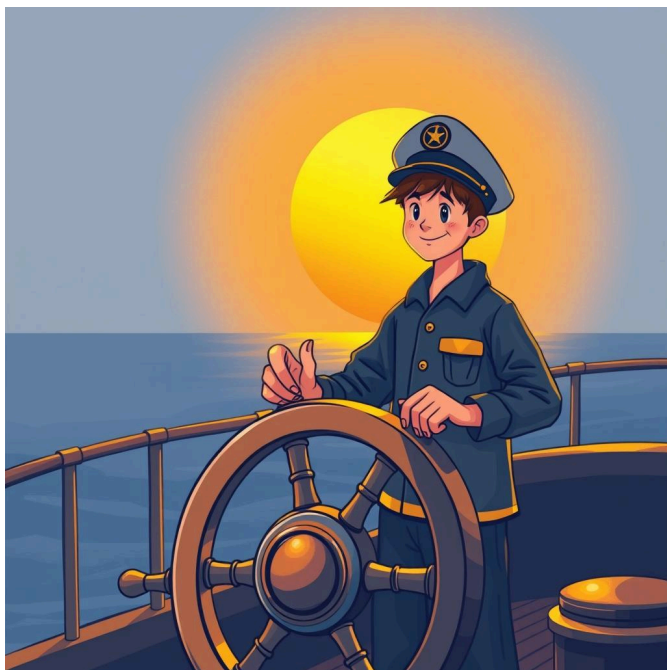
Pick something you’re learning right now – a math topic, a drawing skill, a sport, anything.

Try doing it two ways:

1. First, ask someone (or a computer) to just give you the answer or do it for you. How does that feel?
2. Then try doing it yourself, even if it’s hard. Ask for *hints* if you get stuck, but don’t ask for the answer.

Which way taught you more? Which way felt better when you finally got it right?

That proud feeling when you figure something out on your own? That's what being a captain is all about.



Captain of a Fleet



So far, you've been the captain of one ship with a small crew. But what if the job is really, *really* big?

What if you need to explore three islands at the same time?

You can't sail to three places at once. But you *can* send three ships.

More Ships, More Speed

Imagine you need to get ready for a big voyage. There are three jobs:

1. Fix the sails.
2. Load the food.
3. Draw the maps.

If one crew member does all three jobs, one after another, it takes all day. But if you have *three* crew members, each doing one job at the same time? You're done by lunch.

That's the magic of working in parallel. Instead of one ship doing everything, you have a little fleet. Each ship handles one piece of the mission. They all work at the same time. When they're done, you put the pieces together.



But Here's the Tricky Part

More ships means more to keep track of. You can't just send three ships off and hope for the best. You need to make sure they're not crashing into each other!

What if Rusty is loading food onto Ship A, but Echo is also loading food onto Ship A? Now you have double the food on one ship and none on the other two. What a mess!

The captain's most important job with a fleet is **coordination**. That means making sure each ship knows:

- What *their* job is.

- What is *not* their job.
- How their piece fits with the other pieces.

The secret is to find jobs that don't bump into each other. Fixing sails and loading food are separate jobs. They use different parts of the ship. Different supplies. Different skills. They can happen at the same time without any trouble.

But "fix the sails" and "repaint the mast" can't happen at the same time – because they both need someone climbing the same mast! You'd want to do those one after another instead.

Splitting the Work

Before you send your fleet out, you need to think carefully about how to divide the job. Ask yourself:

Can these pieces be done separately? If Rusty doesn't need to wait for Echo's work, and Echo doesn't need to wait for Compass, they can all work at the same time. That's a great split!

Do any pieces depend on each other? If Echo needs the maps before she can navigate, then the maps need to be done *first*. That piece has to come before the others.

Will anyone need the same tools? If two crew members both need the only hammer on the ship, someone has to wait. Plan around that.

Splitting work well is one of the hardest parts of being a fleet captain. But it's also one of the most powerful things you can learn.



Putting the Pieces Together

Each ship comes back with its piece of the mission done. Now you need to put it all together.

Sometimes this is easy. Ship A has the food. Ship B has the maps. Ship C has fresh sails. Nothing overlaps. Everything fits together like puzzle pieces. Beautiful!

But sometimes the pieces don't quite match. Ship A changed the way the cargo is organized. Ship C moved some cargo to make room for the sails. Now the cargo area is a jumbled mess because both ships rearranged it differently.

When this happens, the captain has to step in. You look at both plans, figure out what fits, and make one final version that works. This is something only *you* can do. Your crew can do the work, but you understand the whole picture.

Your Job Gets Bigger

When you go from one ship to a fleet, your job changes. You do less sailing and more *planning*.

With one ship, you might help scrub the deck sometimes. With a fleet, you're too busy making sure all the ships are heading in the right direction.

This is normal. As the captain of a fleet, your most important skill isn't sailing – it's *thinking*. Thinking about what can happen at the same time. Thinking about what has to happen in order. Thinking about how the pieces fit together. You become more like a coach than a player. A coach doesn't run on the field. A coach watches the whole game, sees the big picture, and tells each player where to go. That's you, Captain.

Teams of Captains



Here's one more level to think about. What if you're not the only captain?

In really big projects, there might be a whole *team* of captains. Each captain has their own crew and their own ship. Together, the team handles a mission that's too big for any one captain.

When a team of captains works together, they need the same things your crew needs: clear communication, good rules, and a shared plan. The rulebook matters even more now, because *every* captain's crew is reading it. If the rulebook is

good, every ship does things the same way. If the rulebook is messy, every ship is different and nothing fits together.

The best teams share what they learn. When one captain discovers a new trick, they tell the others. When one captain makes a mistake, they share the story so nobody else makes the same one. That's how a team gets better together.

How Many Ships Is Too Many?

Here's a surprise: more ships isn't always better.

If the job is small, sending three ships is actually *slower* than sending one. Why? Because of all the extra planning! You have to split the work, brief each crew, check on each ship, and put the pieces together at the end. For a small job, that planning takes longer than just doing the job with one crew.

A good fleet captain knows when to send the whole fleet and when to send just one ship. The fleet is for big missions with parts that can happen at the same time. One ship is for everything else.

Captain's Log: The Three Ships Disaster

I had a simple job. Build a new dock for the harbor. I decided to be clever and use all three ships.

Ship A would build the left side of the dock. Ship B would build the right side. Ship C would build the walkway connecting them.

Sounds great, right? Wrong.

Ship A built their side three feet high. Ship B built their side four feet high. When Ship C tried to connect them with a walkway, it was lopsided. Also, Ship A used round posts and Ship B used square posts, so nothing matched.

I should have agreed on the height and the style *before* I sent them out. Instead, I spent the whole afternoon rebuilding the dock myself.

Sometimes one ship, working carefully, beats three ships in a hurry.

Try This!

Find two friends or family members. Give everyone the *same* task: draw a house. But don't talk to each other while you draw!

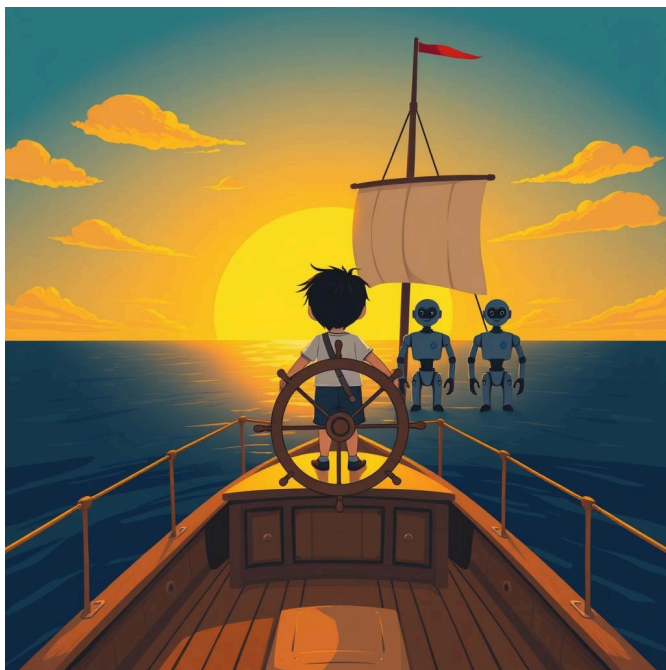
When you're done, try to combine the three drawings into one picture. Do the houses match? Are they the same size? The same style?

Now try again. This time, spend two minutes *planning* together first. Agree on the size, the color, and the style. Then draw separately.

Did the second try work better? That's the power of coordination!



Go Build Something



You made it, Captain. You've learned a lot.

You know how to meet your crew and what makes each of them special. You know how to check their work and keep things safe. You know how to give clear orders and write a good rulebook. You've heard the stories of what goes wrong – and you know how to handle it. You know when to ask for help and when to do things yourself. You even know how to run a whole fleet.

That's pretty impressive for someone your age.

The Crew Changes. The Ship Stays.



Here's one last thing I want you to remember.

Your crew will change. New helpers will show up. They'll be faster, smarter, and better at their jobs. The crew you work with today won't be the same crew you work with next year. That's okay. That's how it's supposed to be.

But the *ship* stays. The ship is your project – the thing you're building. Your rules, your plans, your ideas. The crew comes and goes, but the ship is yours.

And *you* stay. You are the captain. You were the captain when you started this book, and you'll be the captain long after you close it. The tools will change. The helpers will change. But you – your brain, your curiosity, your heart – that's the part that matters most.

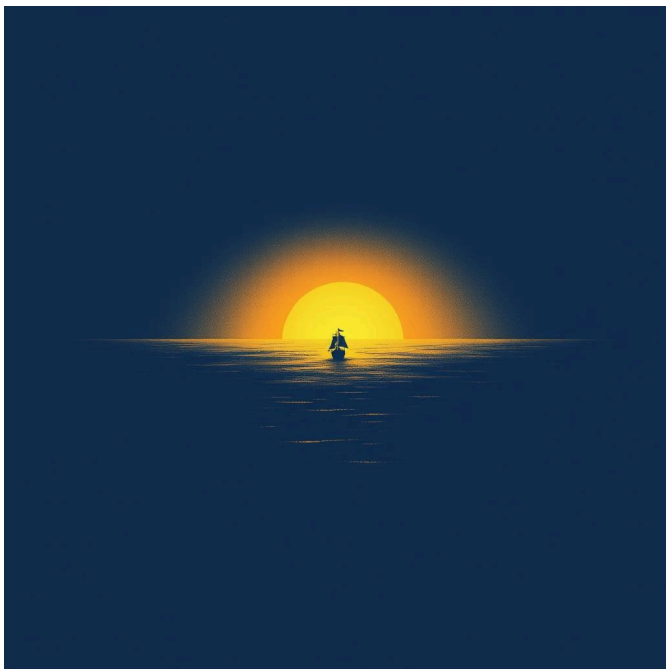
You Don't Need Permission

You don't need to be a grown-up to start building things. You don't need a fancy computer. You don't need to know everything first.

You just need to be curious. Ask a question. Try something. See what happens. If it breaks, figure out why. If it works, figure out why too.

The best captains in history weren't the ones who waited for perfect weather. They were the ones who raised the sail and figured out the wind as they went.

One Last Order, Captain



Tonight – not tomorrow, not next week, *tonight* – try something new. Ask a computer a question you’ve been wondering about. Build something small. Write a story and ask an AI to help you make it better. Draw a picture and see what happens when you describe it to a helper.

Start small. See what your crew can do. Learn from the mistakes. Then try something bigger.

Your crew is ready. Your ship is waiting. The ocean is wide and full of islands nobody has explored yet.

Go build something, Captain.

Fair winds and following seas.

*To my kids —
you are the best crew I have ever had.
This whole thing was for you.
Always.*